India takes this challenge seriously and is prepared to shoulder its responsibilities fully. We have started to conclude white shipping agreements and cooperate on coastal and EEZ surveillance with some of our immediate neighbours. India participates in arrangements like the ReCAAP and the SOMS 10 mechanism for maritime safety. We have also taken an active role in fighting piracy, both to our West and East. Since 2008, we have continued to conduct anti-piracy patrols in the Gulf of Aden and other maritime routes in the region. The Indian Navy has undertaken about fifty anti-piracy escort missions. It has contributed overall to greater maritime safety in the region and enabled the reduction of the High-Risk Area in December 2015, thereby cutting shipping insurance costs.

Security challenges in the Indian Ocean are addressed by each player in their own way. In India's case, they are essentially an outcome of national capabilities, buttressed by participation in relevant regional bodies. The ASEAN Regional Forum, in particular, is evaluated highly by India as a broad-based platform. Closer to home, India is developing trilateral cooperation with Sri Lanka and Maldives. Where naval interests are concerned, the steady growth of the thirty-five-nation Indian Ocean Naval Symposium (IONS) over the last decade has been a very encouraging development. It has helped to promote a shared understanding of maritime issues, enhance regional maritime security, strengthen capabilities, establish cooperative mechanisms, develop inter-operability and provide speedy responses.

Moving from policy to performance, it is evident that navies working together in pursuit of shared security goals have a stabilizing impact. India participates in a number of bilateral exercises with Singapore, Sri Lanka, France and Australia, amongst others. In addition, we partner the US and Japan for the Malabar set of exercises. To some of the Indian Ocean island states, India has supplied naval equipment, provided training and undertaken hydrographic services. And its maritime horizons today clearly include partners in East Africa.

Reconstituting a community identity in the Indian Ocean is a painstaking endeavour. In its structured format, it would require oceanic forums like the Indian Ocean Rim Association (IORA) to acquire greater content and